

Media Studies, Grade 11

Open

EMS30

This course emphasizes knowledge and skills that will enable students to understand media communication in the twenty-first century and to use media effectively and responsibly. Through analysing the forms and messages of a variety of media works and audience responses to them, and through creating their own media works, students will develop critical thinking skills, aesthetic and ethical judgement, and skills in viewing, representing, listening, speaking, reading, and writing.

Prerequisite: English, Grade 10, Academic or Applied

Strands

The expectations in this course are organized into the following strands:

- A. Understanding and Interpreting Media Texts
- B. Media and Society
- C. The Media Industry
- D. Producing and Reflecting On Media Texts

A. UNDERSTANDING AND INTERPRETING MEDIA TEXTS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Understanding and Responding to Media Texts:** demonstrate understanding of a variety of media texts;
- 2. Deconstructing Media Texts:** deconstruct a variety of types of media texts, identifying the codes, conventions, and techniques used and explaining how they create meaning.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Understanding and Responding to Media Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

Purpose and Audience

- 1.1** identify and explain the purpose and audience of a variety of media texts (*e.g., explain the purpose of a print advertisement and identify how the advertisement makes an emotional appeal to its audience; explain the purpose and audience of a website that promotes a healthy lifestyle; explain why a music video is an example of both entertainment and promotion; explain the purpose of paid product placements in film; identify the target audience of a campaign on workplace safety and explain their answer*)

Teacher prompts: “What is the purpose of this text? How do you know this? Who created the text? Who benefits if the message is accepted?” “What do the cover and title of this CD suggest about the music or the artist? How does the packaging attract the intended audience?”

Message and Meaning

- 1.2** identify and explain the messages in and meanings of media texts (*e.g., identify the messages conveyed about female body image in an advertisement for jeans; explain both the stated and implied meanings of an advertisement for mouthwash or deodorant; explain what the design of a hockey jersey implies about the team and about the person who wears the jersey; explain the overt message of an infomercial; explain the implied message in the front cover artwork and design of a science textbook*)

Teacher prompts: “What information is stated on this poster? What message is implied?” “Why would a travel brochure include photographs of tourists?” “What were the major themes of the last movie you watched?”

Audience Responses

- 1.3** compare their own and others’ responses to a variety of media texts and explain how audiences’ backgrounds affect the ways in which they negotiate meaning (*e.g., compare and contrast their response to a music video with their parents’ responses; compare and contrast male and female reactions to various magazines; analyse how the ages and experience levels of computer users affect their use and enjoyment of a blog; explain why they have a different reaction to newspapers than their teachers do; describe how an individual’s interpretation of a text can be connected to social class or position; suggest how an employer and a Grade 9 student might react differently to advertisements that promote apprenticeship programs*)

Teacher prompts: “How might your response to a celebrity endorsement of a product differ from that of a friend? How do you think your values and beliefs, and those of your friend, would affect your responses?” “How might a person from a First Nations community respond to the film versions of the Pocahontas story that we watched?” “How does your own world view shape your response to media representations of poverty or homelessness?” “How might print advertisements for luxury items and experiences [*e.g., tropical vacations*] be interpreted differently by people from different socio-economic backgrounds?”

2. Deconstructing Media Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

Codes and Conventions

2.1 identify the codes and conventions used in media texts and explain how they help to create meaning (*e.g., explain why the symbol of a rose appears in the logo of a company that sells skin products; explain why a close-up of a clenched fist is used to convey anger; identify how the colours of characters' clothing are used to indicate heroic or villainous intent; explain why soft lighting is used in a scene of two people kissing; explain how background music is used to indicate danger in a movie; identify and explain the formulaic resolution of a typical family sitcom; chart the types of camera shots used in a television commercial*)

Teacher prompts: “What do the types of camera shots in this soap opera suggest?” “What conventions of television journalism do entertainment news programs and sports broadcasts share?” “How do filmmakers use music in movies to influence the emotional reaction of the viewer?” “How does the opening title sequence in a television sitcom [*situation comedy*] draw the viewer in and foreshadow the content?”

Language and Point of View

2.2 analyse how the language, tone, and point of view used in media texts work to influence the interpretation of messages (*e.g., analyse the language used in a sports broadcast and explain its purpose and effect; identify the use of euphemisms to promote a particular point of view in a press conference; analyse the language used in a politician's campaign material and explain its effect; explain why comedians use exaggeration in their routines; describe how language and tone are used in warnings about copyright infringement on DVDs to convey the message effectively*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is the term ‘collateral damage’ used instead of ‘civilian deaths’ in political press conferences?” “How and why does a television news anchor change his or her tone of voice and vocabulary depending on the news story being reported?”

Genre and Form

2.3 describe the characteristics of particular media genres and forms, and explain how they help to convey meaning and influence the audience (*e.g., explain how the elements of a movie trailer for an action/adventure film create audience expectations; compare the design of tabloid and broadsheet newspapers and explain their appeal to specific audiences; describe the key features of a web page, such as hypertext and navigation toolbars, and identify their purpose; explain how and why a narrative has to be changed when it is translated from novel to film; explain the use of thought bubbles in a comic strip; explain how sampling from pop songs is used by a rap artist to create meaning; identify the key ingredients that are part of every reality television show, such as the underdog character, the “challenge”, the reward*)

Teacher prompts: “Why do audiences enjoy the formulaic plots used in soap operas? Where else do you see this type of plot being used?” “Why do fashion magazines use a combination of photographs, graphics, and text? Why do these magazines include articles about trends, clothing advertisements, and perfume samples?”

B. MEDIA AND SOCIETY

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Understanding Media Perspectives:** analyse and critique media representations of people, issues, values, and behaviours;
- 2. Understanding the Impact of Media on Society:** analyse and evaluate the impact of media on society.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Understanding Media Perspectives

By the end of this course, students will:

Individuals and Groups

- 1.1** analyse the representation of groups and individuals in media texts and comment on the perspectives, beliefs, or biases that are evident in the texts (e.g., *create a collage of familiar stereotypes in fashion magazines and explain the overall impact of these images; compare media representations of workplaces, vacation experiences, or family life to their own experiences in those areas and suggest reasons for differences; discuss how the message of a popular television program would change if the main characters were from a different socio-economic or ethnic group; explain the effects of the inclusion, exclusion, or positioning of people or groups in magazine advertisements; compare the ways in which television shows, news stories, and advertisements depict the elderly and suggest reasons for differences among them*)

Teacher prompts: “Do you see people you can identify with on television? Why or why not?” “What negative stereotypes are used in this text?” “Do you think the creator of this text was a member of the group being depicted in the text? Why or why not?” “Whose voices are missing, silenced, or discounted in the text?” “When advertisements show men in caregiving situations, to what extent are the depictions stereotypes? Why might that be the case?” “Why are fashion models usually young and slender? What does this suggest about societal norms?”

Current Issues

- 1.2** analyse media representations of current social, political, and cultural issues and events, and explain how the representations might affect the audience’s interpretation of the issues (e.g., *analyse media coverage of a war or uprising and explain how this coverage might affect the audience’s reaction to the conflict; assess the effectiveness of anti-smoking public service announcements for a teen audience; examine news coverage of Aboriginal communities and analyse the possible effect of the coverage on both Aboriginal and non-Aboriginal audiences; compare the coverage of current events in mainstream media with coverage in alternative periodicals, websites, or video documentaries*)

Teacher prompts: “When you research a current international news event, how can you ensure that you obtain a wide variety of perspectives on this event?” “How can the selection of photographs for a newspaper change the messages that the audience receives about an international disaster?”

Behaviours and Attitudes

- 1.3** analyse the representation of behaviours and attitudes in media texts and comment on how they influence the behaviours and attitudes of the audience (e.g., *analyse the news coverage given to the achievements of a local hero; compare the attitudes depicted in a newspaper during a conflict with the attitudes in a feature film or television drama created after the conflict was resolved; evaluate the extent to which the reporting of an actor’s or athlete’s successes and failures influences popular opinion; examine how a celebrity’s homophobic or racist statement is treated in a tabloid newspaper and in an alternative newspaper, and identify reasons for differences*)

Teacher prompts: “What is your impression of the attitudes that family members have towards one another in various popular television series?” “How are bullies and bullying portrayed similarly or differently in news reports, hockey broadcasts, and children’s cartoons? Why?” “Do you think the glamorization/derision of particular celebrities in the media is merited? Why or why not?”

2. Understanding the Impact of Media on Society

By the end of this course, students will:

Canadian Identity

2.1 evaluate the impact of mass media on perceptions of Canadian identity (e.g., evaluate the impact of American satellite radio stations on programming by Canadian radio stations and analyse the possible effect on Canadian audiences; compare the number of screens dedicated to Canadian, American, and foreign films in local cinemas and discuss the possible effects of this breakdown on local moviegoers; examine the impact on Canadian society of the availability of Canadian content in split-run American magazines)

Teacher prompts: “Do you think the coverage of Canadian junior hockey in the Canadian edition of an American sports magazine accurately reflects Canadian interests? Why or why not? How does this coverage compare to the coverage of American college football in the same magazine? What effect might these levels of coverage have on a young Canadian athlete?” “How does the national and international media coverage of Canadian athletes in international competitions affect Canadians’ and non-Canadians’ understanding of Canadian values, beliefs, and attitudes?” “What role has the national and international media played in students’ perceptions of Canada’s armed forces?”

Health and Relationships

2.2 analyse the impact of the media and of communication technologies on health, relationships, and interpersonal communications (e.g., compare the uses and effects of text messaging and face-to-face dialogue; assess the effects that e-learning has had on traditional schooling; analyse the effects of using documentaries and/or websites to support the curriculum in a health or leadership class; explain how public service announcements affect the way in which society views bullying; discuss ways in which the rise of online communities has changed the lives of people struggling with body image)

Teacher prompts: “What role might print or online articles about nutrition play in people’s lives?” “How could you help elementary students understand the importance of Internet safety?”

Global Awareness and Globalization

2.3 assess the impact of the media on countries, cultures, and economies around the world and/or the relationships among them, focusing on globalization (e.g., examine the interplay between North American musical trends and world music styles; examine how media coverage of major crises can influence the response of the international community; compare Canadian television commercials to those broadcast in other countries; research the impact of North American pop culture on the global marketplace; identify five globally recognized logos and report on each corporation’s global reach and impact on society; compare the ratio of box office receipts from international and domestic sources for Hollywood films and discuss some of the possible reasons for this; explore how the programming for major film festivals showcases a variety of global voices)

Teacher prompts: “To what extent does the media coverage of a major natural disaster influence the response from the Canadian government? From Canadians in general? What factors determine how long the event will be prominently featured in the mainstream news media in Canada?” “How might the importing of American sitcoms affect local television production in Canada? What impact might that have on Canadian culture?” “Why might people in developing countries want to watch American blockbuster films?” “How does the global distribution of media contribute to or detract from the creation of Canadian cultural products?”

Privacy

2.4 examine the ways in which the media and communication technologies can infringe on the privacy rights of individuals, and how consideration of those rights affects the behaviour of the media industry (e.g., discuss whether and how school surveillance technologies affect student behaviour; explain why news outlets do not immediately release the names of people who are injured or killed; discuss the conflict between the privacy rights of celebrities and the rights of journalists to meet the audience’s desire for information; identify the ways in which camera phones are changing expectations of privacy in public situations)

Teacher prompt: “Why do the producers of documentaries and reality television programs ask participants to sign release forms permitting the use of their images in promotional material?”

Effects of Using Media Technology

2.5 explain how people use media and communication technologies in their personal and working lives and identify some of the effects of those technologies (*e.g., explain why students might choose a particular Internet search engine to research an essay topic, and discuss the ways in which research has changed with the invention and increasing sophistication of search engines; conduct a survey to determine trends in the use of media technologies by particular audiences and the effects of these trends; analyse the use of cell phones and text messaging for organizing political or social action; examine how technology enables multi-tasking; research the ways in which electronic communication technologies have extended the boundaries of work and the impact of this change on vacations and work-life balance; explain how new technologies help to inform people about emergency situations such as severe weather conditions or missing children, and analyse the results of such technology use; explain how digital photography affects the ways in which people transmit and receive images, and explore the impact on society*)

Teacher prompts: “How does an electronic greeting card send a different message than a postcard?” “Why do the police have computers installed in their cruisers?” “How has technology changed the way people acquire information about consumer products?”

C. THE MEDIA INDUSTRY

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Industry and Audience:** demonstrate an understanding of the ways in which the creators of media texts target and attract audiences;
- 2. Ownership and Control:** demonstrate an understanding of the impact of regulation, ownership, and control on access, choice, and range of expression.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Industry and Audience

By the end of this course, students will:

Targeting Audiences and Assessing Responses

- 1.1** analyse how and why media companies, sponsors, and advertisers identify and target audiences based on socio-economic factors and how they assess and react to audience response (e.g., identify and discuss examples of television programs that target different demographic groups; explain why certain commercials are aired during prime-time dramas featuring teenagers; investigate and explain the rationale behind the product placement of luxury items in certain feature films and television programs; explain why certain corporations are interested in sponsorship arrangements with certain schools; research and compare methods used by different companies to measure television audience ratings; analyse box office reports and music sales charts and suggest how companies may react to the results; research how the responses of test audiences and focus groups have affected decisions about content in movies or advertising campaigns)

Teacher prompts: “How and why do media companies gather information about different groups of consumers? How do companies use demographics [information about age, gender, income, education, and so on] to determine how to advertise to a particular target group or market?” “Why do major movie studios conduct audience screenings prior to the release of their films?”

New Technologies and Content Delivery

- 1.2** identify some of the ways in which the delivery of content to audiences has changed as a result of new technologies and describe the effects of those changes (e.g., explain how the widespread use of MP3 players has forced record companies to change their distribution methods; explore the effect of increasing numbers of television channels on mainstream television programming; research how the fragmentation of television audiences has changed the nature of shared cultural experiences; research and analyse the ways in which digital television systems allow media consumption to be individualized)

Teacher prompts: “Consider a television program that airs only on a specialty cable channel. What are the advantages and disadvantages for the viewer? For the producer?” “What effect might the fragmentation of media audiences have on shared cultural identity?”

Marketing Across Platforms

- 1.3** explore how a media product or personality is marketed to an audience across a range of media platforms (e.g., identify and explain several ways in which animated films are promoted through fast food chains; research the media strategies used to give a pop star “brand” identity; explore the ways in which video games and television cartoons are used to promote products and celebrities)

Teacher prompt: “How many ways is this new film being marketed? Which ones do you think are the most effective for its target audience? Why?”

2. Ownership and Control

By the end of this course, students will:

Regulation

2.1 explain how government regulations and industry codes affect the way in which media companies operate (e.g., *examine the role of the CRTC in promoting Canadian content on television and radio; compare and contrast the effects on media businesses of the regulations governing media ownership in Canada and in the United States; analyse several print advertisements to see how well they conform to the Canadian Code of Advertising Standards; explain how copyright law and guidelines for protecting intellectual property rights affect the media industry*)

Teacher prompt: “How do programming requirements for children’s television shows in Canada affect what is produced and who is allowed to participate?”

Concentration of Ownership and Its Effects

2.2 research the current patterns of media ownership and explain the impact of these patterns on access, choice, and range of expression (e.g., *identify the owners of each of the media outlets in the local community; identify the holdings of a major media conglomerate and explore the relationships that the holdings have to each other; research the advantages and disadvantages of the media being controlled by a small number of institutions in Canada and in the United States; explain how the concentrated ownership of media can privilege certain perspectives*)

Teacher prompts: “Why is it likely that a news report that people read or view in one part of Canada will be exactly the same as in another part? How does that affect the quality of the information that the audience receives?” “What is the largest media company in Canada, what does it control, and how might this affect the choices available to consumers and producers?” “If you were the owner of several media outlets, how could you use your various companies to promote your latest feature film? What advantages would that give you over an independent film producer?”

Technology and Perspectives

2.3 explain the impact of technology on the perspectives and voices available to media audiences (e.g., *explain how the Internet has broadened access to alternative music; explain how computer technology has allowed individuals*

and small organizations to publish sophisticated media texts; explain how blogs have provided access to divergent opinions on world events; explain how the cost of access to the Internet can exclude some perspectives from online communities)

Teacher prompts: “Whose perspective is presented in this blog? How does that perspective differ from the one you hear on the evening news?” “Why is this video only available online?” “Whose voice is heard? Why?” “How does digital photography allow a wide range of Canadians to share their stories and perspectives?” “Why do Internet ‘hackers’ target large media corporations?” “How does digital recording technology affect the sharing, distribution, and sale of cultural products such as movies and television shows among a global audience?”

Gatekeepers

2.4 analyse the factors that determine what media texts will or will not be made available to the public (e.g., *research how newspapers determine which stories will appear on their front page; research how content ratings are applied to video games; debate controversial music lyrics and the limits on artistic expression; explain how commercial concerns may limit the range of choices available in a bookstore*)

Teacher prompts: “Do you think this rap song is likely to be used in television shows or commercials? Why or why not? Do you agree with that reasoning?” “Who decides which video games will be made available to consumers in Canada?”

Impact of New Technology on Industry

2.5 analyse the effects of new technologies on the media industry (e.g., *report on the ethical and economic implications of digital sampling in the music industry; examine the effects on the film and television industry of the online proliferation of amateur videos*)

Teacher prompt: “How has the newspaper industry been affected by the emergence of online news providers and of ‘citizen journalism’? How has the industry reacted?”

D. PRODUCING AND REFLECTING ON MEDIA TEXTS

OVERALL EXPECTATIONS

By the end of this course, students will:

- 1. Producing Media Texts:** create a variety of media texts for different audiences and purposes, using effective forms, codes, conventions, and techniques;
- 2. Careers in Media Production:** demonstrate an understanding of roles and career options in a variety of media industries;
- 3. Metacognition:** demonstrate an understanding of their growth as media consumers, media analysts, and media producers.

SPECIFIC EXPECTATIONS

1. Producing Media Texts

By the end of this course, students will:

Purpose and Audience

- 1.1** create media texts for different purposes and audiences (*e.g., explain the choices made in creating a water-safety poster for adults as opposed to one created for children; create separate public service announcements to promote healthy eating among teenage males and females; adapt an article from a national newspaper for a community newspaper; explain what information and ideas they intended to convey in a comic that they created*)

Teacher prompt: “How would you create comic books that address a serious issue [*e.g., racism*] in ways that target different groups of people, such as adults, adolescents, and children?”

Form

- 1.2** select an appropriate form for a media text they plan to create, and explain why they made that choice (*e.g., adapt a short story for a comic book or a podcast; write or produce news stories about the same event for radio and for the school newspaper*)

Teacher prompt: “What form(s) of media would you use to encourage automobile drivers to pay strict attention to the road when they are at the wheel? Why?”

Using Media Conventions and Techniques

- 1.3** select and use the conventions and techniques of a particular form to produce media texts (*e.g., create suspense in a video by using low camera angles, eerie music, and dim lighting; design a website for young children that includes animated clip art and coloured text; design a business card that students at their school could hand out when looking for part-time work or volunteer opportunities; create a print advertisement about drug abuse aimed at a teen audience, using print design conventions; create a collage for children that presents a message about healthy eating habits*)

Teacher prompts: “What conventions and techniques would you use to design a calendar based on your hobbies or interests?” “What techniques would you use to create a software presentation for your fellow students on the topic of homophobia?”

Language and Point of View

- 1.4** select and use the appropriate level of language, tone, and point of view when creating media texts for specific purposes and audiences (*e.g., record a commentary on a school sports event in the style of a favourite commentator; write an article targeted for a mainstream national newspaper and then rewrite it for an alternative newspaper, using an appropriate style for each*)

Teacher prompt: “If you were to write a jingle for a radio commercial or podcast aimed at attracting Grade 8 students to your school, what kinds of lyrics and music would you use?”

Production Process

- 1.5** employ planning strategies for pre-production, production, and post-production (e.g., *create a storyboard when planning a video; create a detailed plan for a multimedia campaign that includes television or radio commercials, print advertisements, and product tie-ins; create a chronology of events in outline form to plan a script; use free association to brainstorm visual images to be used in a collage*)

Teacher prompt: “What steps would be involved in planning, recording, and marketing a CD or digital compilation of your favourite songs?”

Credits and Permissions

- 1.6** research and obtain the necessary credits and permissions for the media texts they create, and explain the importance of doing so (e.g., *list the guidelines that exist for citing material from newspapers or magazines posted on the Internet; research the guidelines for using an artist's music in a film, video, or television program*)

Teacher prompts: “When is it necessary to obtain permissions for material that you use in a media text you create?” “How did you deal with the issue of credits and permissions when you made your video?”

2. Careers in Media Production

By the end of this course, students will:

Definition of Roles

- 2.1** identify and distinguish between the various positions involved in the production of a variety of media texts (e.g., *use the Internet to research the specific roles involved in the production of a magazine; using the “behind the scenes” features on a DVD, explore the ways in which a television director interacts with writers, actors, and sound, camera, and lighting crews during the production process*)

Teacher prompts: “How does the role of a film director differ from that of a film producer?” “How does the job of a copy editor compare to that of a news reporter?”

Career Opportunities

- 2.2** research careers in the media and in related industries (e.g., *write a report on the career opportunities in the media for an editor, producer, cinematographer, carpenter, film lab technician, entertainment lawyer, actor, accountant, caterer, web designer, reporter, or photographer; interview an employee of a local media business, such as a television studio or advertising agency, and create a presentation or write an article about the interview*)

Teacher prompt: “What employment opportunities in the media emphasize oral communication?”

3. Metacognition

By the end of this course, students will:

Media Consumer

- 3.1** reflect on how their behaviours as consumers of media have changed in response to their study of media (e.g., *maintain a journal to reflect upon, record, and explain personal media use and preferences over the course of the term; give a short speech that compares their current and previous understandings of bias in media texts and the effects that their new level of understanding has had on their media consumption*)

Teacher prompt: “How has studying a variety of media texts affected your perceptions of the role you play in creating meaning from texts?”

Media Analyst

- 3.2** reflect on the strategies they used to evaluate media representations (e.g., *reflect on why it is important to discuss their opinions with others when examining a variety of perspectives on media representations; identify key questions that were effective for analysing media representations; reflect on how they evaluate a film by using comparisons; identify the criteria they use to determine whether to keep watching a television series; explain how interviewing store managers and clients helped them evaluate window displays*)

Teacher prompts: “When looking at an advertisement, what strategies do you use to evaluate the representations of gender?” “How do you evaluate point of view in a media text? Which strategies are the most effective?” “In the photograph of a conflict, who is in a position of power? Who is excluded from the photograph? From whose perspective is the photograph taken?” “How would you decide which images to use if you were designing a poster for a school dance?”

Media Producer

3.3 select and present work that reflects their growth and competence as media creators, and explain the reasons for their choices (*e.g., create a presentation that explains their growth in the use of production techniques; mount a classroom or hallway display of various works with brief descriptions of why each one was chosen*)

Teacher prompt: “Of all the media texts that you have created this year, which ones would you want to share outside of class? What method would you use to share them? Why?”